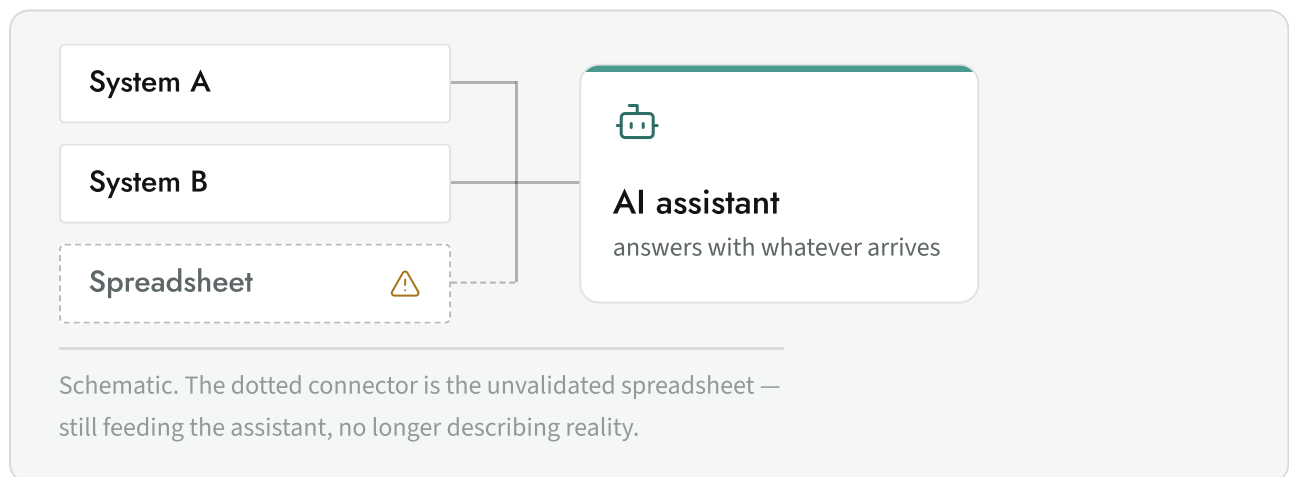


The *Wiring* Behind the Model

Nine things that decide whether AI actually works for your business

I spent a good chunk of last year telling people that the way into AI for a small or mid-sized business was to pick the right tool. A chat interface here, an agent there, maybe a custom assistant for the sales team. I was wrong about that, and in reasonably good company: Daniel Kahneman spent a career pointing out that people judge situations almost entirely by what is visible to them at the time, a habit he called WYSIATI, what you see is all there is. The model is what you see. It is glossy, it is demoable, it fits on a slide. What actually decides whether it works is the wiring behind the model, and wiring does not fit on a slide.

Picture a mid-sized distributor that buys an enterprise AI seat licence for its customer service team, then watches the assistant confidently answer a shipment question using data that is three systems and one unvalidated spreadsheet out of date.



The spreadsheet was accurate when someone last saved it. Everything downstream of it has been quietly going south ever since, and the assistant is the first place anyone noticed ...or not.

That is not a model problem.

The model answered exactly as asked. Nobody had told it that the spreadsheet was three weeks stale, because nobody had wired it to anything that could.

Nobody's assistant got any less clever overnight. The wiring behind it simply never changed.

None of this makes the people selling the model wrong to talk about the model, by the way. It is the easiest thing in the room to demo, and demos are how budgets get approved (trust me, I worked as a presales consultant for many years throughout my career). It is just not the thing that decides whether the budget was well spent.

You might suspect this is the kind of point an integration vendor would make to sell more integration (fair, I have some skin in that game, discount accordingly), but the pattern holds up even where nobody is selling anything. McKinsey's own line on the subject, from a May 2026 piece aimed at corporate strategists rather than at anyone's shopping list, borrows from *The Incredibles* to make it: "If everyone is special, then no one is." Generic AI, in other words, has become table stakes. A consulting firm with no integration platform to sell arrives at the same place an integrator would, just from the other direction.

"If everyone is special, then no one is."



— McKinsey, quoting *The Incredibles*
from "From AI Table Stakes to AI Advantage," May 2026

So this paper is not about which model to buy. It is about the nine unglamorous things, the wiring, that decide whether any model, once bought, actually does anything: what you connect to outside your walls, what you trust once it is inside them, who or what gets to see it, what you actually build with it, whether you build it yourself, what one person can do with it before any of the rest is sorted, how you bring people with you rather than past them, what is left to compete on once your rivals have the same tool you do, and how you justify the spend to someone who still remembers the last piece of expensive software nobody used.

Roughly, in that order:

#	CHAPTER	WHAT IT'S ACTUALLY ABOUT
1	External Partners	Connecting new trading partners without three weeks of email tennis, before an EU mandate makes it compulsory anyway
2	Core Systems	Building the stuff you should have without buying it, and making sure you can actually use it
3	Governance & Security	Building what the IT department is supposed to do, before it's too late
4	Use Cases	Building the things you're going to use, before you've lost the plot

5	Build vs. Buy	Why the build vs. buy decision is usually the only one that really counts
6	The Individual Worker ⚡	What is the role of the worker in a process-driven world?
7	People & Change	Why the change management process is the most important one and what to do about it
8	Competitive Edge	What is the competitive edge in a world where data is the only asset that counts?
9	ROI & Finances ⚡	How to measure the ROI of a process-driven world

Two of these, the sixth and the ninth, do not wait for the other seven to be sorted. You can start delegating to AI on a Tuesday afternoon with none of the rest solved. The other seven are more patient with you than the people selling them tend to be.

I will publish one chapter a day over the next nine days, in the order above. Somewhere around chapter three, someone will tell me governance should have come first. They may be right. Ask me again once the wiring is visible and see if I still disagree.

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